

Dr. Marcus Pryce

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling suppressed your research showing that two objects in his collection passed through a dealer linked to questionable wartime sales. He threatened to release correspondence suggesting you had overstated another provenance claim if you challenged him publicly.

What you are hiding

One celebrated article of yours does contain an inference you stated too confidently. The main thesis still stands, but the mistake would be humiliating. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Ask Sebastian what he has discovered in the accession records.
- Determine whether Celeste commissioned outside provenance research.
- Keep Nadia from learning which article Sterling could attack.

What you know about other guests

- Celeste has doubts about the Star Bowl's provenance serious enough to seek independent review.
- Sebastian found an archival document that appears to contradict one exhibition label.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

A black-star archive seal from your research packet was found in the Donor Salon. During the poison window, the Media Room archive scanner records you copying correspondence related to the weak inference in your celebrated article. The scan sequence clears your timing but exposes the scholarly mistake Sterling was using against you.

IF MURDERER

At 6:43 you carried a research packet to Sterling. You poisoned the cordial after he refused to release the acquisition files. One black-star seal from your packet adhered beneath the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Sterling had proof that I overstated one inference years ago. I was afraid he would use a real mistake to discredit research that threatened him. The archive scanner records me copying the correspondence behind that mistake throughout the poison window. That is embarrassing, but it clears me.

IF MURDERER

Sterling understood the power of uncertainty. He only needed one flaw in my record to bury everything else I had found. I brought him the file, poisoned his cordial, and left with the papers. One seal stayed behind. I spent my life reconstructing chains of custody. Mine ends here.